47TH ANNIVERSARY



FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

'The best' is a difficult concept to master. If you ask a parent, "Which of your children is the best?", it really can have no answer. But a striving for excellence is what defines us—each of us tries to be the best we can become and then better that. In a nation's journey, this continual quest to create a better tomorrow becomes its primary life-force. And this process cannot unfold without us reviewing the best of the past, which has shaped our present. India, as an independent nation, has turned 75 this year. As a tribute to this milestone, INDIA TODAY has chosen on its 47th anniversary to do a special issue to celebrate this immense journey with a retrospective gallery of the events and the personalities who have made this country what it is today.

THE BEST OF INDIA

How does one capture the entire life of a nation in the rearview mirror? How can you accumulate all the infinite moments of accomplishments that over a billion people have marked and then choose between them? In a real sense, it's impossible to quantify greatness. What we have taken recourse to, therefore, is only an approximation. But one underpinned by a certain logic: whatever events, moments or projects we zeroed in on, they have touched the lives of many. This is easy to understand, say, with a Bhakra Nangal Dam, or the high-yielding variety of seeds that ushered in the Green Revolution, freeing the country from endemic want and giving us self-sufficiency in food. Or with the Mid-Day Meal Scheme that benefitted millions of children, or a famous battle victory like the Kargil war that ensured intrusions by the Pakistan army on the LoC were rebuffed. But this criterion can be applied even if a 'best moment' arises within the mysterious ambit of an individual's psychology. A Dilip Kumar, for instance, cut so deep into himself in his search for an inner Devdas that it famously affected his real life. But what he gave us was a truly collective moment. Meena Kumari's ethereal loneliness belongs to us, as does Shammi Kapoor's infectious joy.

With this governing principle in mind, we sought to analyse India's passage through the decades within 34 broad categories. Many of them have to do with the State or the evolution of our polity in the most general terms. Thus, political movements make the cut, as do economic policies and landmarks in infrastructure or breakthrough initiatives in health and welfare. Since India as a nation-state is defined by its adherence to the Constitution, one of the most progressive documents of its kind in the world, we have similarly found our judicial history to be an indispensable part of it—landmark judgments that extended freedoms for everybody thus feature on these pages. So do the decisive battles India has fought, securing our freedom on another front, and the diplomatic successes we have achieved in peacetime, extending our esteem in the world.

Outside of the affairs of the State, though, there are domains vital to our existence. Breakthroughs and innovations in science and its applications affect us all; environmental initiatives